JamBook

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Summary of Project

JamBook is a mobile app designed to streamline the studio booking process for student musicians at the Area-01 Studio near the UW campus. Currently, students must call or visit the front desk to check availability and book slots, which is highly inefficient. JamBook addresses this by providing real-time booking information and allowing users to reserve or cancel slots directly through the app. JamBook aims to solve a significant problem by reducing human interaction, improving efficiency, and empowering artists to take control of their studio schedules.

Project Analysis

Value Proposition + Primary Purpose

The main purpose of JamBook is to automate the inefficient, manual studio booking process. It provides real-time availability and booking options, eliminating the need to visit the front-desk or call staff, which is prone to delays and misunderstandings. I had a personal incident where one of my bandmates had cancelled our slot without me knowing, and I didn't find that out until I was already at the place. I could've called and asked the front-desk, but calling someone requires more energy and effort (and social skills) than just pulling up your phone and checking on the app. There is no app for this, which is what JamBook is aiming to address.

Target Audience

JamBook is designed for student musicians who use the Area-01 Studio near the University of Washington (Seattle) campus. I’m an active member of the music clubs of UWS, so outreach should be as straightforward as dropping a few messages in the right group chats. The main challenge would be prolonged user-adoption, which can be managed if the app does all the right things in the right way.

Success Criteria

Success will be measured by:

- **Real-time booking accuracy**: The app must display and update booking information accurately.
- **User adoption**: Tracking the number of users (musicians) engaging with the app.

- **Satisfaction**: I’d preferably like to collect feedback on time saved and booking efficiency by releasing surveys for my friends/volunteers to fill out in the music clubs of UWS.

Competitor Analysis

There is no known booking system at your university similar to JamBook. This lack of competition presents an opportunity to fill an unmet need for student artists.

Monetization Model

JamBook will be free to users, focusing on delivering value without ads. I could explore the possibility of potential compensation from the university itself because I’d be putting in the man-hours to solve a real administrative problem, saving time for both staff and students, but I intend to keep the app completely free.

Initial Design

The MVP will focus on the core functionality of booking studio slots in real-time:

- **Real-time slot availability**: Show which slots are available, booked, or recently canceled, using a clear, up-to-date interface.
- **Slot reservation and cancellation**: Allow users to book and cancel slots easily. This will include preventing double-bookings and ensuring cancellations are updated across the system.
- **User notifications**: Notify users when cancellations happen (only to the users who subscribe to notifications for a particular slot), so they can take advantage of newly available slots.
- **Database management**: A simple backend to store and retrieve booking information, possibly integrating with any existing university APIs (if they exist, which I’m not too sure of). Information on past bookings can be archived for a limited time (e.g., one month) so the user can see their booking history.

Taking these requirements into account, I may need to implement some or all of the following:

- Start with user-focused design principles, keep the interface minimal, and test with a few students for feedback. Focus on showing essential data like free/occupied time slots clearly.

- Reach out to the university's IT or administration department to inquire about existing systems, booking databases, or APIs. If no API exists, I’ll need to build the system from scratch or integrate with any existing manual workflows via web scraping (for example).

- Use a robust database (e.g., Firebase or AWS DynamoDB) that supports real-time synchronization. Implement concurrency controls to avoid double-bookings.
- Use push notification services (e.g., Firebase Cloud Messaging) or in-app alerts to inform users when slots become available. This will require tight integration with the backend and user-specific preferences for notifications.

Challenges and Open Questions

- I’m not sure if I want to give the user the ability to book slots anonymously. On the contrary, offering contact information for the person who’s booked a particular slot might open up opportunities for people to reach out to them and negotiate a better time that suits both parties. Asking for contact information for a simple app like this might be too much though, so that’s probably left as an optional field that the user can choose to populate when booking slots. This proposition requires further thought and investigation on my part.
- I’ll also need to account for bad actors who’ll want to book out all the slots for a particular day, or people who’d try to work around the system by having all members of the same band book different slots under different names, so that they can use the studio for the entire day. I’d have to be careful about implementing restrictions in this regard.